

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

A play for two people

Wheeler Hubbell

WHEELER HUBBELL PUBLISHING

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

WHEELER
And the body?

JUSTIN
The body was our claim.

A pause.

WHEELER
I thought I was reading the record.

JUSTIN
You were reading the pieces.

WHEELER
And the person?

A pause.

JUSTIN
We wrote that.

WHEELER pulls the first connecting strip free.

The pieces remain on the wall.

The human outline shifts.

For the first time, it no longer holds automatically.

Blackout.

Part 4 of 4 — The Release

The light returns.

The silhouette remains on the wall.

Three seams are pinned open:

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

UNRELIABLE

DID NOT RELIABLY ARRIVE AT THE
REQUIRED TIME.

INTRUSIVE

CONTACT AFTER AN EXPLICIT REFUSAL OF
ENGAGEMENT.

ARROGANT

JUSTIN SPOKE PRECISELY.

WHEELER FELT BEHIND.

The connecting tape hangs loose.

Some strips have fallen to the floor.

*From a distance, the arrangement still resembles a
human body.*

Up close, its construction is visible.

WHEELER stands before it.

JUSTIN remains several paces away.

A pause.

WHEELER

The body's still there.

JUSTIN

The arrangement is.

WHEELER

Up close, it's only pieces.

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JUSTIN

It was always pieces.

WHEELER touches one of the loose joins.

WHEELER

Do I remove all of it?

JUSTIN

No.

WHEELER

Why not?

JUSTIN

Because we made it.

WHEELER

Then it stays as a person.

JUSTIN

No.

WHEELER

As what?

JUSTIN

Evidence of the construction.

A pause.

WHEELER looks at the opened findings.

WHEELER

The lateness remains.

JUSTIN

Yes.

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

WHEELER

The contact after refusal remains.

JUSTIN

Yes.

WHEELER

The precision remains.

JUSTIN

Yes.

WHEELER

My feeling remains.

JUSTIN

Yes.

WHEELER

Arrogance does not.

JUSTIN

Not as established by those facts.

WHEELER

Nothing has been acquitted.

JUSTIN

No.

WHEELER

Nothing has been erased.

JUSTIN

No.

WHEELER

Then what failed?

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

JUSTIN

The body we claimed they made.

A pause.

JUSTIN walks toward the wall.

He stands beside the silhouette.

It covers only part of him.

*WHEELER looks from the fixed arrangement to
JUSTIN.*

WHEELER

It's too small.

JUSTIN

It was always too small.

WHEELER

Then why did it feel enormous?

JUSTIN

Because everyone stood behind it.

A pause.

WHEELER

Does standing beside it acquit you?

JUSTIN

No.

WHEELER

Does it erase the conduct?

JUSTIN

No.

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

WHEELER

Does it make anyone's pain unreal?

JUSTIN

No.

WHEELER

Then what changed?

JUSTIN

The silhouette lost custody.

A pause.

JUSTIN raises one hand.

Then the other.

He begins moving slowly.

*His live shadow crosses the wall and separates from the
fixed outline.*

The silhouette remains.

Its seams remain exposed.

JUSTIN's movement becomes freer.

His shadow leaves the white paper.

WHEELER reaches toward the lamp.

JUSTIN

What are you doing?

WHEELER stops.

WHEELER

Adjusting the light.

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

JUSTIN

Why?

WHEELER

Your shadow is leaving the paper.

JUSTIN

Let it.

WHEELER

Then the outline will no longer resemble you.

JUSTIN

It resembles where I stood when you traced me.

A pause.

WHEELER lowers his hand.

He leaves the lamp untouched.

WHEELER

How will I understand where you are now?

JUSTIN

Stay in the room.

WHEELER turns toward him.

JUSTIN keeps moving.

*The fixed light no longer tries to return him to the
outline.*

*The black silhouette remains on the wall: partial,
opened, and visibly made.*

WHEELER

What do I do with the outline?

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

JUSTIN

Hold it where it belongs.

WHEELER

And you?

JUSTIN looks at him.

His hands remain in motion.

JUSTIN

Let me move.

Blackout while the movement is still occurring.